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INDUSTRY
INTERNSHIP SYSTEM

UX/UI DESIGN TOOLS EVALUATION

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Project Background

The Industry Internship System project is a 16-week internship initiative led by Sue Pearson, the Industry Relationship Manager. The project involves developing a web-based application designed to streamline the internship placement process. The system allows students, administrators, and clients to log in, manage, and communicate effectively. Stephen Li's roles in this project include UX/UI design in Figma, junior software testing under the guidance of Rasika Pradeep Jayasundara, and data analysis using Power BI to create dynamic dashboards. The Lead Data Analyst, Naiya Rani, will use Python for data analysis. The goal is to visualize data trends and potential issues, providing valuable feedback to Sue Pearson, who is the client for this project.

Objective

This report aims to evaluate six UX/UI design tools: Figma, Adobe XD, Sketch, InVision, Axure RP, and Balsamiq based on their suitability for the Industry Internship System project. The evaluation criteria include ease of use, features, platform compatibility, cost, and collaboration.

Evaluation Table

	0.3	**0.25**	**0.2**	**0.15**	**0.1**	**1** **Final score**
Criteria Tool	Ease of Use	Features	Platform Compatibility	Cost	Collaboration	
Figma	9 points	9 points	10 points	9 points	10 points	
	= 9 * 0.3 = 2.7	= 9 * 0.25 = 2.25	= 10 * 0.2 = 2	= 9 * 0.15 = 1.35	= 10 * 0.1 = 1	**9.3**
Adobe XD	8 points	8 points	8 points	7 points	8 points	
	= 8 * 0.3 = 2.4	= 8 * 0.25 = 2	= 8 * 0.2 = 1.6	= 7 * 0.15 = 1.05	= 8 * 0.1 = 0.8	**7.85**
Sketch	8 points	8 points	5 points	6 points	7 points	
	= 8 * 0.3 = 2.4	= 8 * 0.25 = 2	= 5 * 0.2 = 1	= 6 * 0.15 = 0.9	= 7 * 0.1 = 0.7	**7**
InVision	7 points	7 points	9 points	8 points	9 points	
	= 7 * 0.3 = 2.1	= 7 * 0.25 = 1.75	= 9 * 0.2 = 1.8	= 8 * 0.15 = 1.2	= 9 * 0.1 = 0.9	**7.75**
Axure RP	6 points	9 points	8 points	5 points	7 points	
	= 6 * 0.3 = 1.8	= 9 * 0.25 = 2.25	= 8 * 0.2 = 1.6	= 5 * 0.15 = 0.75	= 7 * 0.1 = 0.7	**7.1**

Balsamiq	10 points	6 points	8 points	9 points	8 points	
	= 10 * 0.3 = 3	= 6 * 0.25 = 1.5	= 8 * 0.2 = 1.6	= 9 * 0.15 = 1.35	= 8 * 0.1 = 0.8	**8.25**

Evaluation Criteria

1. Ease of Use (0.3):

   The intuitiveness of the tool's interface and the learning curve involved in mastering it.

2. Features (0.25):

   The range and depth of functionalities offered by the tool, such as prototyping, design systems, and interactive elements.

3. Platform Compatibility (0.2):

   The ability of the tool to operate across different operating systems and devices, and how well it integrates with other tools.

4. Cost (0.15):

   The expense involved in acquiring and maintaining the tool, including licensing fees and any additional costs.

5. Collaboration (0.1):

   The tool's ability to support real-time collaboration among team members, including sharing, commenting, and co-editing capabilities.

Tool Evaluation

1. Ease of Use (0.3)

- Figma: 9 points. Figma is known for its intuitive interface, which is accessible to both beginners and experienced designers. The learning curve is minimal.
- Adobe XD: 8 points. Adobe XD is user-friendly but might require some familiarity with other Adobe products for seamless use.
- Sketch: 8 points. Sketch has a simple and straightforward interface but is available only on macOS, limiting accessibility.
- InVision: 7 points. InVision Studio is feature-rich but may require a steeper learning curve due to its advanced features.
- Axure RP: 6 points. Axure RP is powerful but complex, with a steep learning curve, making it less accessible for beginners.
- Balsamiq: 10 points. Balsamiq is designed for simplicity, focusing on low-fidelity wireframing, making it extremely easy to use.

2. Features (0.25)

- Figma: 9 points. Figma offers a comprehensive set of features, including vector editing, prototyping, and design systems, all within a cloud-based environment.
- Adobe XD: 8 points. Adobe XD provides robust prototyping tools, integration with Adobe Creative Cloud, and unique features like voice prototyping.
- Sketch: 8 points. Sketch has strong vector editing and design system capabilities, with a vast plugin ecosystem to extend functionality.
- InVision: 7 points. InVision excels in prototyping and collaboration but lacks some advanced design tools found in other platforms.

- Axure RP: 9 points. Axure RP is unmatched in detailed prototyping and interaction design, making it ideal for complex, high-fidelity prototypes.
- Balsamiq: 6 points. Balsamiq is limited to wireframing, offering fewer advanced features compared to the other tools.

3. Platform Compatibility (0.2)

- Figma: 10 points. Figma is platform-independent, accessible on any device with a web browser, making it ideal for diverse teams.
- Adobe XD: 8 points. Adobe XD is available on both macOS and Windows, with excellent integration across Adobe Creative Cloud.
- Sketch: 5 points. Sketch is limited to macOS, restricting its use in teams with mixed operating systems.
- InVision: 9 points. InVision is cloud-based, accessible on any device, and integrates well with other tools.
- Axure RP: 8 points. Axure RP is available on both macOS and Windows, though it is more resource-intensive.
- Balsamiq: 8 points. Balsamiq is available as a web app and desktop version, making it accessible across platforms.

4. Cost (0.15)

- Figma: 9 points. Figma offers a free plan with essential features, with affordable paid options for more advanced needs.
- Adobe XD: 7 points. Adobe XD has a free tier, but advanced features require a subscription, which can be costly.
- Sketch: 6 points. Sketch requires a one-time purchase with yearly renewals for updates, making it more expensive over time.

- InVision: 8 points. InVision offers a free version with limited features, with paid plans providing full access.
- Axure RP: 5 points. Axure RP is one of the more expensive tools, with a subscription model that may not be cost-effective for all teams.
- Balsamiq: 9 points. Balsamiq is affordable, with a low monthly subscription fee, making it accessible for most budgets.

5. Collaboration (0.1)

- Figma: 10 points. Figma excels in real-time collaboration, allowing multiple users to work on the same project simultaneously.
- Adobe XD: 8 points. Adobe XD offers good collaboration features, though not as seamless as Figma's real-time editing.
- Sketch: 7 points. Sketch relies on third-party tools for collaboration, which can be less integrated and smooth.
- InVision: 9 points. InVision provides strong collaboration tools, particularly within its cloud ecosystem.
- Axure RP: 7 points. Axure RP supports collaboration but is more suited for individual use due to its complexity.
- Balsamiq: 8 points. Balsamiq supports basic collaboration, suitable for its focus on wireframing.

Final Scores

- Figma: 2.7 + 2.25 + 2 + 1.35 + 1 = 9.3
- Adobe XD: 2.4 + 2 + 1.6 + 1.05 + 0.8 = 7.85
- Sketch: 2.4 + 2 + 1 + 0.9 + 0.7 = 7
- InVision: 2.1 + 1.75 + 1.8 + 1.2 + 0.9 = 7.75

- Axure RP: 1.8 + 2.25 + 1.6 + 0.75 + 0.7 = 7.1
- Balsamiq: 3 + 1.5 + 1.6 + 1.35 + 0.8 = 8.25

Conclusion

Based on the evaluation, Figma emerges as the most suitable tool for UX/UI design in the Industry Internship System project, excelling in ease of use, features, platform compatibility, and collaboration. Adobe XD follows closely, particularly strong in integration with other Adobe products and advanced prototyping features. InVision and Balsamiq are effective for prototyping and collaboration, though Balsamiq is more specialized in wireframing and lacks the advanced design features found in other tools. Axure RP, while powerful for detailed prototyping, may not be the best fit for this project due to its steep learning curve and higher cost. Sketch, while powerful on macOS, is limited by its platform exclusivity and reliance on third-party plugins for collaboration.

Given Figma's superior performance across multiple criteria, it is the preferred choice for UX/UI design in this project. Its cloud-based nature, coupled with real-time collaboration capabilities, makes it ideal for a team working across different locations and systems.

However, Business Analyst Dana has suggested a potential approach: while Figma remains the primary UX/UI design tool, wireframes could be created using Balsamiq. Dana’s reasoning is that as the author of the project requirements document, she is more familiar with the project's needs. She proposes to assist by constructing wireframes in Balsamiq, after which the team designer, Stephen Li could complete the mockups in Figma. Dana’s experience in previous projects involved using Balsamiq for wireframing, and she has found it challenging to

create wireframes in Figma. Therefore, this hybrid approach could leverage the strengths of both tools and ensure the project meets its design goals effectively.

Reference

Soegaard, M. (2024, May 30). The Top UX and UI Design Tools for 2024: A Comprehensive Guide. Interaction Design Foundation - IxDF. https://www.interaction-design.org/literature/article/ux-design-tools-definitive-guide